FOR LEADERSHIP REVIEW
SEPTEMBER 2026

ATLANTA PHILHARMONIC ORCHESTRA

visual standards

The permanent visual system for the orchestra: how color, type and imagery work together, and what stays fixed from one season to the next.

Seven sections are presented here for your consideration, with one example of how they resolve on the page. A more technical companion will be created once decisions are made.

01 The logo, brought into the system
02 The color system
03 One color per concert
04 Range within one color
05 Backgrounds
06 Layering, the throughline
07 Typography

bringing the ring into the palette

The wordmark does not change. The ring is the only part of the logo that carries color, and it currently runs a six-hue spectrum that predates the palette. Extending it to all eleven colors would bring the mark in line with everything around it.



CURRENT · SIX HUES

A rainbow, though not the flag. It has no pink, brown, black or white, so it sits outside the color system.



PROPOSED · ALL ELEVEN

The complete palette in flag order, so the mark says the same thing as the material around it.

The wordmark is untouched

No change to the letterforms, spacing or proportions. This is a change to the ring only.

One-color version stays

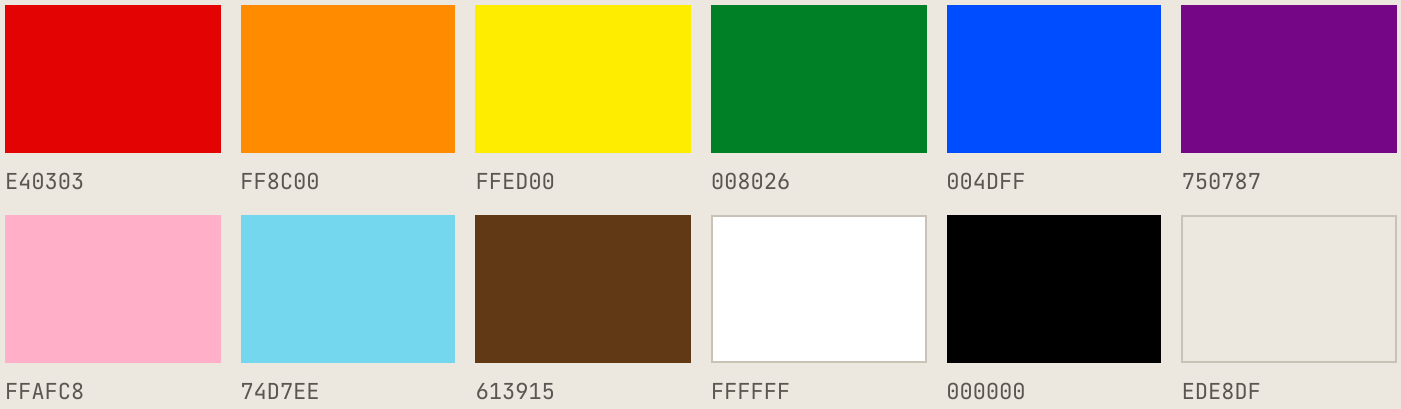
Embroidery, single-color print and small sizes keep the solid mark exactly as it is today.

A concert variant

On concert pieces the ring may run one color's range instead, so the mark stays inside the one-color rule.

the palette, and what it means

The palette is the eleven colors of the Progress Pride flag. Using it in full is how the orchestra says who it is for, without needing to write it out. Everything the Philharmonic produces draws from these colors.



ELEVEN FLAG COLORS BLACK & WHITE ALSO SERVE AS SECONDARIES CREAM · NEUTRAL GROUND

All eleven, or one

The full palette belongs to the orchestra as a whole, and a single color belongs to a single concert. What the system avoids is the middle ground, where two or three colors are picked out and used together.

Why that matters

A handful of the colors together tends to read as an ordinary color scheme, while the complete set is recognisable as the flag. Keeping those two situations separate protects the meaning.

Cream is a ground

Cream is not a brand color and is never given to a concert. It is the warm paper the work sits on, and layered color reads more clearly against it than against pure white.

one color for each concert

A concert is assigned a single color from the palette, and everything for that concert uses it — poster, email, social. This is connected to a concert's theme, and has been an APO norm for years.



Color Me Romantic	Christmas	Hooked on Classics	Teach the World to Sing	Music of the Spheres
OCT 17	DEC 12 & 13	FEB 21	APR 24	JUN 5

SEASON 21 SHOWN AS AN EXAMPLE · ASSIGNMENTS ARE SET FRESH EACH SEASON

NOT ASSIGNED THIS SEASON



YELLOW GREEN LIGHT BLUE BROWN

Four chromatic colors are unassigned this season and remain available for a future one. Black and white stay secondaries and are never given to a concert.

One color is not one flat tone

Each color opens into a range: lighter tints, the color itself, deeper shades. Five steps, the same formula for every color, which gives a single-color piece depth without reaching for a second color.



TINT TINT BASE SHADE SHADE

> A volunteer building a flier only ever has to know one color, which keeps the work on-palette without anyone having to police it.

range within one color

One color per concert only holds up if that color can do more than one thing. Every palette color extends into the same five-step range, mixed by formula instead of picked by eye, so a poster and a social post built months apart still match.



Three steps, not five

An image uses at most three of the five, and skips a step between them. Neighbouring steps sit too close to read apart at a distance, and the layering on the next page depends on that separation.

Where the range is shorter

Pink, yellow and light blue are already light, so their lighter mixes disappear against cream or white and the useful range runs from the color downward. The formula is the same; the usable part of it is not.

what sits behind it

Three backgrounds carry the whole system. Cream and warm off-black are neutrals, not palette colors, so either can sit under any concert color without becoming a second color on the piece. The same three tones of orange sit on all three below, so the only thing changing is what is underneath.



Cream `#EDE8DF`

For print, and for anything built on overlapping shapes — the overlaps darken visibly against it.



Warm off-black `#4A4540`

The dark default for concert pieces. Warm enough that the concert color stays vivid.



Black `#000000`

Held back for the season-level pieces, where the full palette needs the most contrast it can get.

Why not true black throughout

True black mutes a color sitting on it. The slightly warm dark lets the same orange read brighter without changing the ink, though the two are hard to tell apart unless you see them together.

Why brown is not one of them

Brown belongs to the palette, so a brown background would make brown the concert's color. The brown and black stripes also carry specific meaning in the flag, which is not a job for a background.

how the imagery is built

Imagery is built by repeating a subject in offset copies, so an image behaves a little like a musical figure that recurs. There are two ways to make the copies separate from one another, and both use only the concert's own color.



SOLID, THREE TONES

Each copy takes a different step of the color's range.



OUTLINED, THREE TONES

The same idea opened up. Lighter on the page, and each copy stays legible.



OVERLAPPED, ONE TONE

One color twice. Where the copies cross, it deepens on its own.

The colors are the point

Both techniques produce three values from a single color, so the depth comes out of the palette and not from effects layered on top. A concert piece should not need a second color to feel finished.

Still to be drawn

The shapes here are stand-ins. How far the copies offset, how heavy the outlines run and how far the tones travel are all decisions for a designer; what is settled is the approach and not the drawing.

the two typefaces

A geometric sans built on the same shapes as the logo carries titles, dates and anything short, and a serif carries program notes and longer reading. Both are free and available in Canva, Google Docs and PowerPoint, since volunteers build most of what the public sees.

TITLES & LABELS

Outfit

music of the spheres

JUNE 5, 2027 · 7:30PM · FREE ADMISSION

PROGRAM NOTES

Newsreader

Still open — alternates on page 8

Holst wrote The Planets for a very large orchestra and closed it with a wordless chorus singing offstage. Neptune ends without resolving — the voices simply move further away until a door is shut on them.

Outfit was chosen for matching the stroke weight and circular construction of the logo. The previous pairing was set aside for sitting too close to the Atlanta Symphony. The two runners-up are shown overleaf.

the faces we compared

All three are geometric faces built on circles, like the logo. The test was the lowercase **apo** — a single-storey a with a circular bowl — and whether the face offers enough weights to stay usable at small sizes.

RECOMMENDED

music of the spheres

apo · abcdefg

Outfit

Matches the hairline weight of the logo and carries a full weight range for labels and small print.

CONSIDERED

music of the spheres

apo · abcdefg

Poppins

Available in every tool, with a full weight range. Heavier and rounder than the mark, and widely used elsewhere.

CONSIDERED

music of the spheres

apo · abcdefg

Didact Gothic

Structurally the closest to the mark, but a single weight only, so nothing can go lighter or bolder.

choosing the reading face

This face carries long reading only: program notes, web copy, anything past a paragraph. Because it never appears beside the logo it does not need to match the mark, but it does need to stay comfortable over several paragraphs. All three below are free and in Google Docs, and any of them would serve.

SHOWN THROUGHOUT

Holst closed The Planets with a wordless chorus singing offstage. Neptune ends without resolving; the voices move further away until a door is shut on them.

Newsreader

Open and slightly condensed, so it sets economically in a program. What every example in this document uses.

ALTERNATE

Holst closed The Planets with a wordless chorus singing offstage. Neptune ends without resolving; the voices move further away until a door is shut on them.

Literata

Drawn for long reading on screen and paper alike. Sturdier, and the most comfortable of the three at small sizes.

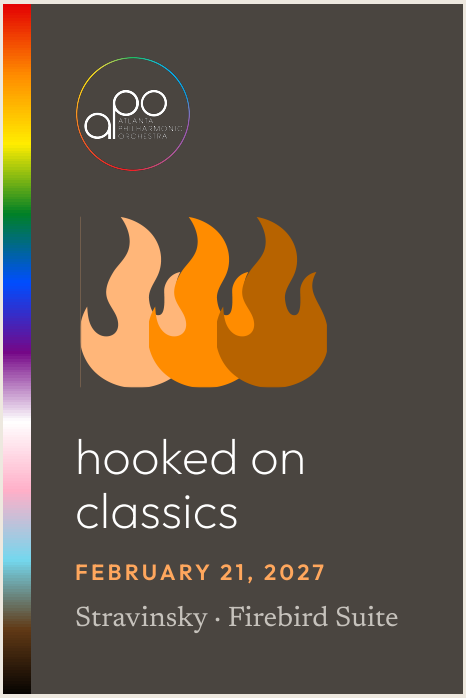
ALTERNATE

Holst closed The Planets with a wordless chorus singing offstage. Neptune ends without resolving; the voices move further away until a door is shut on them.

Spectral

More contrast and a sharper finish. The most formal, and the closest to a traditional concert programme.

the system on a poster



INDICATIVE ONLY · FINAL ARTWORK TO BE DRAWN BY A DESIGNER

A single color in three tones, one repeated shape, and the full palette held to a narrow edge stripe. Nothing here is a new decision; it is the rules in this document applied together. The ground is the warm off-black used for concert pieces, and the date line takes a lighter step of the concert color so small text stays legible against it.

- One color for the concert, drawn from the palette
- Three tones from that color's range, no second color
- One subject, layered in offset copies
- The full palette present, but held to an edge



The overlap rule on cream, sized for social. One color laid down twice, darkening where the copies cross. No second color and no tonal steps — the crossing supplies the third value.

NEXT STEPS

Hand the basic system to a designer — the palette, the tonal ramps and the shape overlap ideas — so the artwork can be drawn properly rather than approximated. The brief overleaf sets out what is fixed and what is theirs.

Continue to refine and improve alongside that work, settling the reading face and testing the system on real pieces before the season is announced.

knowing the neighbours

This is not a competitive exercise. The Philharmonic belongs to the Atlanta Queer Arts Alliance and shares audiences, venues and Pride imagery with its members by design. Knowing what each already does keeps us from arriving at something that looks borrowed.

Atlanta Freedom Bands Founded 1994	Formed because the Pride parade had no marching band. States its mission as increasing LGBTQ acceptance through visibility.
Voices of Note AGMC founded 1981	Parent of the Gay Men's and Women's Choruses and, by its own account, the largest community music organisation in the Southeast at over 260 people.
OurSong, Out Front, Out On Film Alliance members	A mixed chorus, a theatre company and a film festival. Not musical competitors, but they reach the same audience and set the context ours is read in.
Atlanta Symphony Orchestra Founded 1945	The largest orchestra in the city. Its mark draws on the bass clef and the sweep of a baton, and it describes itself as the cornerstone of musical excellence in Atlanta.
Harmonia Atlanta Collaborator	We perform together and its music director has conducted for us. It also sings with Alpharetta, so our material regularly sits beside theirs on a shared programme.
Alpharetta Symphony Suburban peer	A suburban orchestra serving Alpharetta and North Fulton, describing its work as inspiring, educating and enriching. It also performs with Harmonia Atlanta, so our paths cross.
Atlanta Pride Annual	Re-themes and re-logos annually, which is the opposite of what we are building. A permanent system behaves differently from event branding, so they are a useful contrast.

WHAT IS ALREADY SHARED

Visibility as the mission, rainbow color used freely, and the language of transformation. All of it sincere and all of it common ground, which means a decoratively used rainbow says nothing particular about us.

WHAT THAT ASKS OF US

Everyone here can use these colors. What distinguishes us is the all-eleven-or-one rule, a discipline nobody else applies to the same palette.

side by side

The marks together, and what each organisation leads with.


Atlanta Philharmonic


Gay Men's Chorus


Women's Chorus


OurSong


Freedom Bands


Out Front Theatre


Out On Film


Harmonia Atlanta


Atlanta Symphony


Alpharetta Symphony

ORGANISATION	RELATION	COLOR	IMAGERY	VOICE
Atlanta Philharmonic	US	11 OR 1	Tonal/overprint illustration	PLAIN
Atlanta Gay Men's Chorus	ALLIANCE	Red/Yellow	Illustration, varied	HEARTS, MINDS
Atlanta Women's Chorus	ALLIANCE	Purple/Teal	Illustration, varied	HEARTS, MINDS
OurSong	ALLIANCE	10 color rainbow	Illustration, varied	—
Atlanta Freedom Bands	ALLIANCE	6 color rainbow	Photos	VISIBILITY
Out Front Theatre	ALLIANCE	Pink/white + rainbow	Illustration, varied	—
Out On Film	ALLIANCE	6 color rainbow	Typographic, film stills	—
Harmonia Atlanta	PARTNER	8 color rainbow	Simple graphics	EXCELLENCE
Atlanta Symphony	PEER	—	PHOTOGRAPHY	EXCELLENCE
Alpharetta Symphony	PEER	Purple/Black	Photos, soloists	CIVIC

Four of these organisations use a rainbow palette and four use varied illustration, so neither choice sets us apart by itself. The part no one else on this table is doing is our single color per concert, and the tonal layering built from it. Both symphonies lead with photography, which is worth knowing since they are the groups we are most likely to be compared with. The voice column is also useful: several organisations describe themselves in similar terms, so there is room to write more plainly.

what we would hand over

A designer should be able to tell which parts of this are load-bearing and which are simply our first attempt. Both are set out below.

FIXED, AND HERE IS WHY

The eleven colors

The palette is the flag, and the all-eleven-or-one rule keeps that legible instead of decorative. This is the part of the system carrying the meaning. The wordmark is fixed too; only the ring is open.

One color per concert

Each program takes one color and its own range of tones, so an audience learns to recognise a concert on sight.

It has to be buildable

Volunteers produce most of what the public sees, in Canva and PowerPoint. The work is digital first — email, social, web and slides — with print the exception.

YOURS TO DECIDE

The imagery itself

Five subjects, one per concert, drawn as a set that holds together. A single image recolored across the season works when a season has a genuinely unifying idea, but most do not. The subjects we name are prompts, not instructions.

The layering technique

Our reasoning is in section 03. Improve it or replace it, so long as a piece still reads as one color.

Layout and surface

Poster architecture, grid, texture, whether the cream ground stays, how type sits on the page, and how the ring holds eleven colors.

WHAT WE ARE WORKING WITH

Five concerts a year, a volunteer orchestra, free admission, and a palette that has to carry meaning without becoming a gimmick. Each concert should reflect musical identity and the theme.

WHAT IT SHOULD NOT LOOK LIKE

Not the Symphony, and not institutional. Not led by performance photography, which is where most orchestras start and where they end up looking alike. And not an echo of the other queer arts organisations in Atlanta, who are colleagues and not rivals. See page 11 for what is already in use around us.